BATON INDEX

Leadership Succession Intelligence

A RESEARCH BRIEF FOR SEARCH PROFESSIONALS

Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership

Six data-backed findings on how gender shapes who reaches, serves in, and leaves the business school deanship.

618
dean appointments

93
top U.S. schools

1967–2026
six decades

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Prepared for leadership search professionals

A BATON INDEX RESEARCH BRIEF

Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership

Aggregate diversity statistics — “women are now ~30% of business school deans” — hide the mechanisms that actually govern who reaches the corner office, how they get there, and how they leave. Baton Index analyzed **618 dean appointments across 93 of the top 100 U.S. business schools (1967–2026)**, linking each leader’s discipline, PhD pedigree, appointment type, tenure, and departure to school-level data. Six findings emerge that bear directly on how search professionals source, benchmark, and advise.

The six findings

- **The pipeline is gendered by discipline.** 59.6% of female deans come from Strategy/Management vs. 23.8% of men — a 4.1× odds gap; Operations/IS barely feeds women at all.
- **That pipeline is reconfiguring fast.** In the 2020s, Finance/Accounting overtook Strategy as the leading field for female deans, and women shifted from outside hires to internal promotions.
- **A glass cliff runs through interim roles.** Women jumped to 40% of interim appointments in the 2020s — and 56% of interim successors after a *surprise* departure.
- **The tenure ‘gap’ is a mirage.** Women’s shorter average tenure disappears entirely once era and discipline are controlled ($p = 0.744$).
- **The credential bar is rising for women.** 46.7% of 2020s female deans hold elite PhDs vs. 19.1% of men — a 27.6-point gap that flipped in one decade.
- **Academia leads corporate America by ~20 years.** Deans track Fortune 500 CEO diversity at $r = 0.85$ but roughly two decades ahead.

> **HOW TO USE THIS BRIEF**
> Each finding pairs the evidence with a concrete implication for search committees and recruiters. The patterns are sourcing signals, benchmarking guardrails, and talking points you can bring into a committee room.

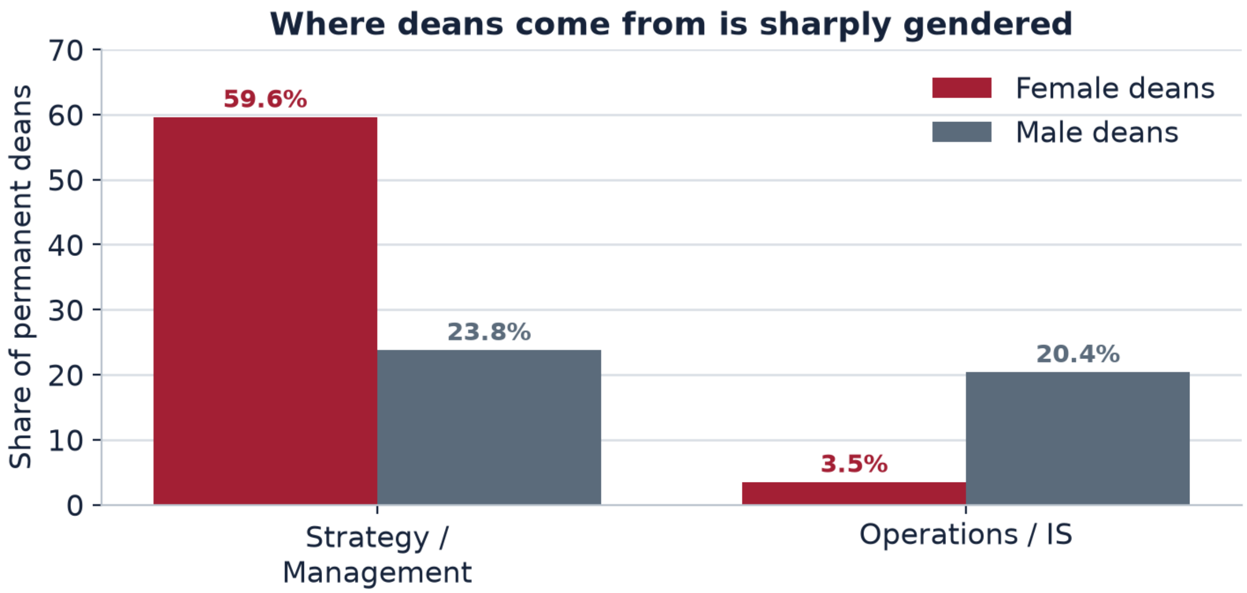
FINDING 1 OF 6

The discipline pipeline

Where deans come from is gendered

Search committees draw from the senior faculty already in the building — so the gender composition of each discipline gets reproduced in the dean's chair. Nearly **60% of female permanent deans come from Strategy and Management, versus 23.8% of men** ($\chi^2 = 29.7$, $p < 0.001$).

In a multivariate model, a Strategy/Management background raises the odds of a female appointment **4.08×** ($p = 0.001$), while Operations/IS cuts them to **0.19** ($p = 0.041$). The appointment mechanism — external vs. internal, associate-dean path or not — does not explain it; discipline does.



Discipline distribution of permanent deans by gender (n = 325).

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

If a committee wants a credible slate of women and is fishing only in Finance or Operations pools, it will come up short by construction. Widen the net into Strategy/Management early — or budget for an external search — and set the client's expectations about supply before the shortlist, not after.

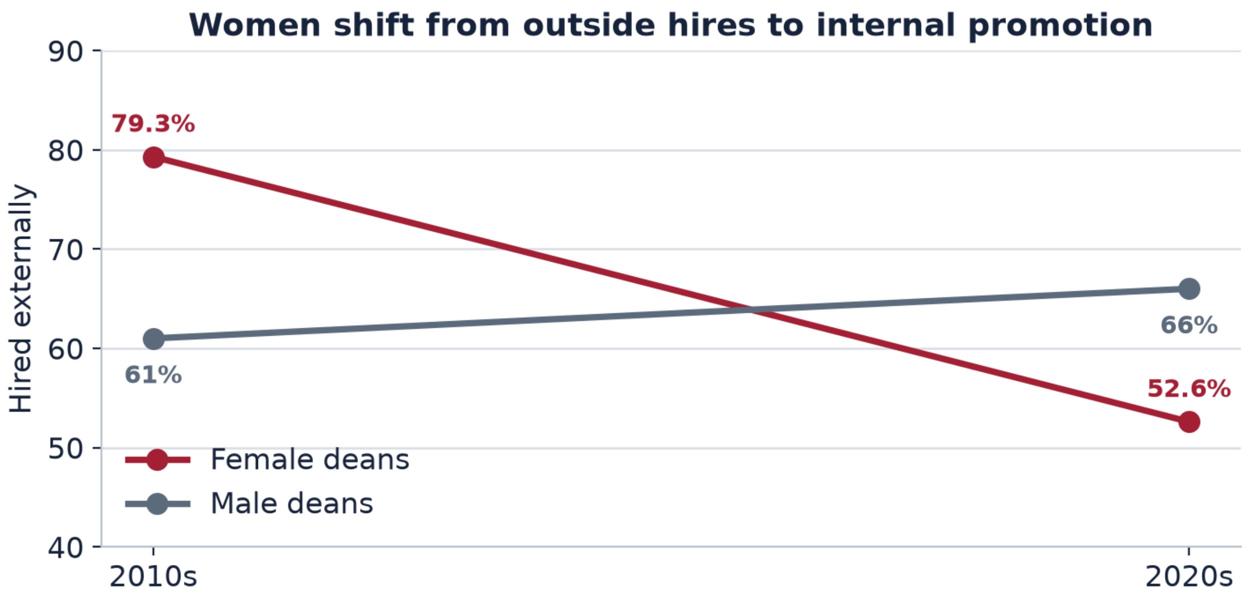
FINDING 2 OF 6

Pipeline reconfiguration

The map is being redrawn — fast

The historical pattern is already breaking. Through the 2010s, Strategy/Management concentration for women intensified (66.7%). In the 2020s, **Finance/Accounting became the leading discipline for female deans (46.7% vs. 40.0% Strategy)** — a statistically sharp shift (Fisher's $p = 0.003$).

It comes with a hiring-channel reversal: female deans moved from **79% external hires in the 2010s to majority-internal in the 2020s** (Female × 2020s odds of external hire = 0.20, $p = 0.016$), and the associate-dean pathway for women doubled from 26% to 53%. The female pipeline is maturing and broadening.



Share of permanent deans hired from outside the institution, by gender and era.

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Two moves follow. First, internal candidates are now where much of the female talent sits — press clients to run a genuine internal assessment, not a courtesy one. Second, yesterday's comps are stale: a 2015 read on 'where women deans come from' will mis-price a 2026 search.

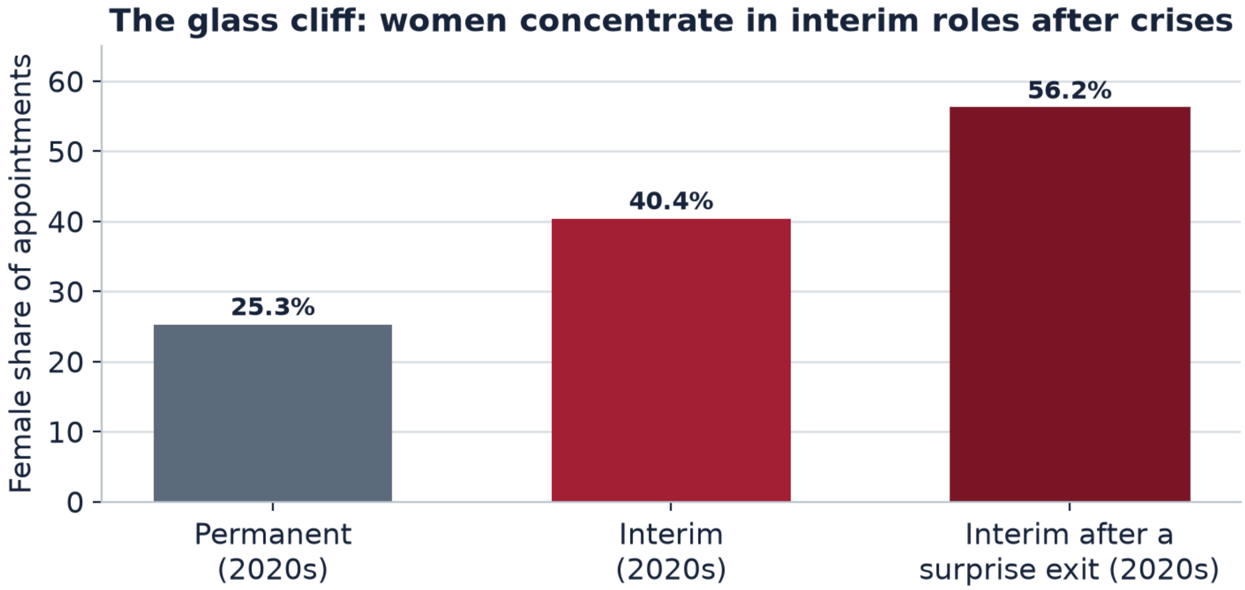
FINDING 3 OF 6

The glass cliff

Women inherit the hardest seats

Interim appointments are time-limited, lower-authority, and increasingly fail to convert — the classic profile of a precarious ‘glass cliff’ role. For three decades women were under-represented in them. In the 2020s that flipped: **women are 40.4% of interim appointments vs. 25.3% of permanent ones** (Female × 2020s odds = 4.24, $p = 0.028$).

The effect concentrates around crises. After a *surprise* departure, **56.2% of interim successors in the 2020s were women**, versus 37% after an orderly transition. Encouragingly, 2020s conversion is tilting the other way — female interims converted to permanent at 25% vs. 11% for men — though the samples are still small.



Female share of appointments, 2020s: permanent vs. interim vs. post-crisis interim.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

When a client calls after a sudden exit, watch the framing. An interim woman parachuted into a crisis is carrying uncompensated risk — and aggregate ‘% women in leadership’ dashboards quietly overstate progress by counting these seats. Advocate for a real conversion path, or a permanent mandate up front.

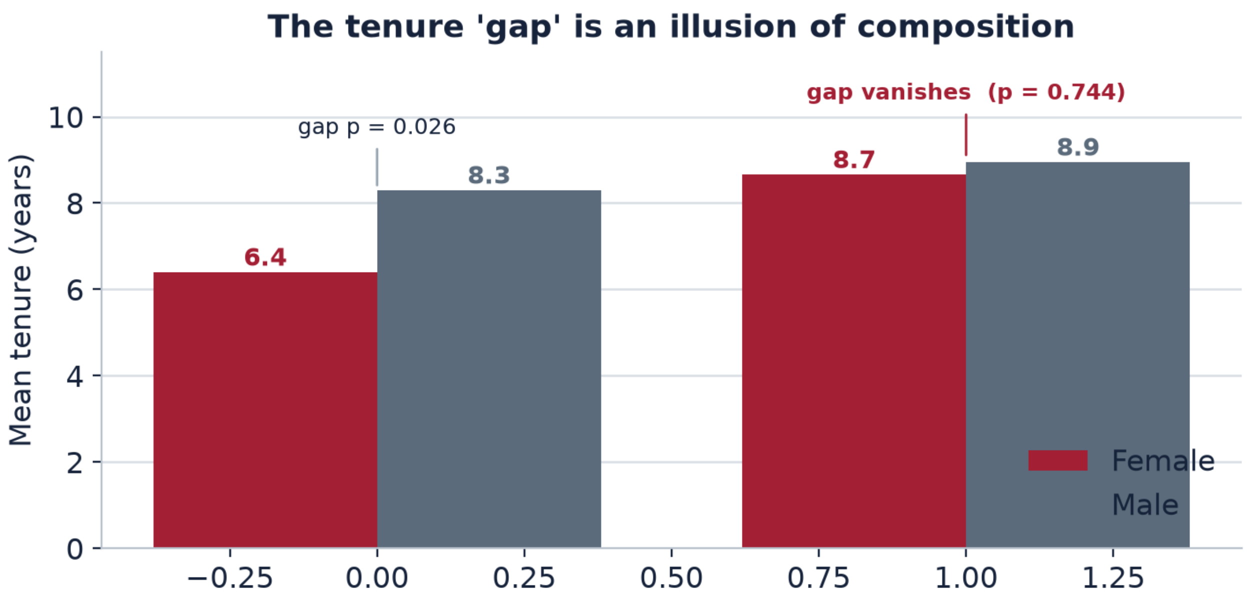
FINDING 4 OF 6

The compositional illusion

The tenure ‘gap’ isn’t real

On paper, women’s deanships look shorter — 6.4 vs. 8.3 years ($p = 0.026$). It is tempting, and wrong, to read that as a performance or fit signal. Once you control for era, discipline, and tier, the gender coefficient collapses to –**0.28 years and is statistically indistinguishable from zero ($p = 0.744$)**.

The real driver is era: *everyone’s* tenures are compressing (2020s deans serve ~9 years less than 1990s deans, $p < 0.001$). Because women entered disproportionately in recent, shorter-tenure cohorts, a raw average manufactures a gap that a like-for-like comparison erases.



Mean dean tenure, raw vs. adjusted for era, discipline, and tier.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

Kill the ‘women don’t stay as long’ objection with the like-for-like number — it is a cohort artifact, not a candidate risk. The genuine story to carry into the room is that *all* dean tenures are shortening, which is reshaping how often your clients will be back in the market.

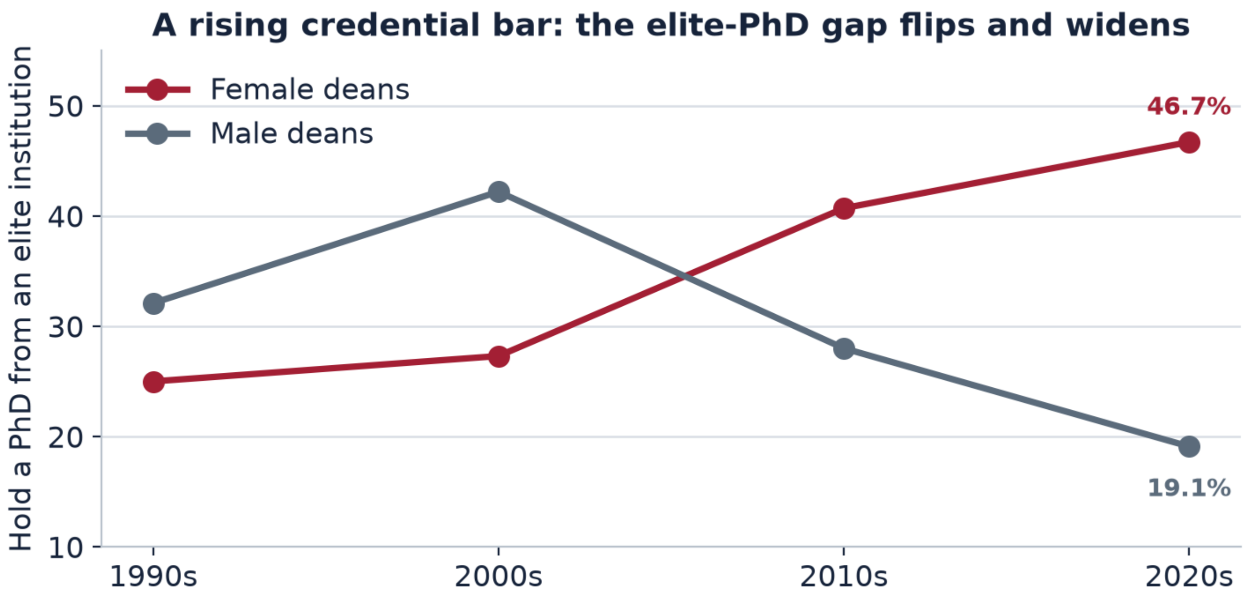
FINDING 5 OF 6

The credential threshold

A higher bar, quietly rising

Across the full sample the elite-PhD rate looks even (38.6% of women vs. 31.7% of men). The time series tells a different story. In the 1990s–2000s men were *more* likely to hold an elite PhD; from the 2010s it reversed and widened. By the 2020s, **46.7% of female deans held PhDs from elite institutions versus 19.1% of men — a 27.6-point gap**, the study's starkest credential asymmetry.

Read together, the signals point one way: as more women enter the market, the women actually selected carry disproportionately elite credentials, while the male pool has broadened its pedigree base.



Share of permanent deans holding a PhD from an elite institution, by gender and era.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

The bench of elite-credentialed women is real and competitive — use it in the pitch. But recognize the flip side: an over-indexed bar means committees may be screening out excellent women without a marquee PhD. Naming that bias explicitly is often what widens a stalled slate.

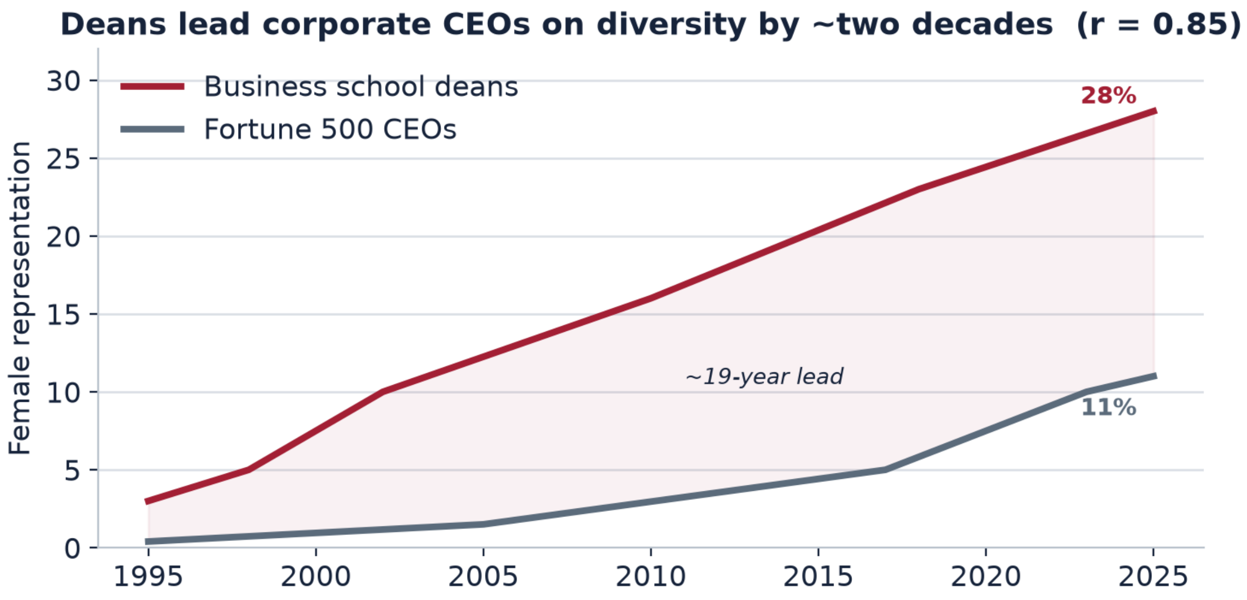
FINDING 6 OF 6

A leading indicator

Academia is corporate America's ~20-year preview

Female representation among business school deans tracks Fortune 500 CEO representation almost in lockstep (**r = 0.85, p < 0.001**) — but roughly two decades earlier. Deans crossed 5% female around 1998; CEOs not until 2017. Deans passed 10% by 2000; CEOs only in 2023. Today deans sit near 25–30% of new appointments while CEOs have just cleared 11%.

More transparent credentialing, accreditation-driven diversity pressure, and a smaller, more fluid labor market let academia move first — which makes the deanship a useful forward read on corporate governance.



Female representation, 1995–2025: business school deans vs. Fortune 500 CEOs.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

For firms that place in both academic and corporate markets, dean-market patterns are an early signal of where board and C-suite demand is heading. The discipline mixes and pathways diversifying among deans today preview the executive pipelines your corporate clients will be chasing tomorrow.

THE PLAYBOOK

What this means for your next search

Six evidence-based moves for committees and recruiters working the leadership market:

- **Scope supply before the slate.** Female candidate depth varies enormously by discipline. Map the pool up front so the client's expectations match reality — and you're not defending a thin slate later.
- **Take internal candidates seriously.** The female pipeline has shifted toward internal promotion; a perfunctory internal look now misses real talent.
- **Treat interim-after-crisis as a red flag, not a win.** Push for a permanent mandate or an explicit conversion path so you're not placing a candidate onto a glass cliff.
- **Retire the tenure myth.** The gender tenure gap is compositional; the real trend is that *all* tenures are compressing.
- **Name the credential bias.** An over-elite bar quietly narrows female slates — surfacing it is often what unblocks a search.
- **Read deans as a leading indicator.** Diversification in the dean market previews where corporate board and C-suite demand is heading.

METHODOLOGY & ABOUT

About this brief

This brief distills a Baton Index working paper, *“Gendered Pipelines, Glass Cliffs, and Compositional Illusions: How Gender Shapes Governance Transitions in the Business School Dean Labor Market.”* Findings draw on a hand-collected dataset of 618 dean appointments (410 permanent, 181 interim) across 93 of the top 100 U.S. business schools, 1967–2026, with primary analysis on the post-1990 period (591 appointments). Dean records were assembled from university websites, press releases, professional profiles, and news archives — not crowd-sourced encyclopedias — and augmented with AACSB Business School Questionnaire data. Estimates come from logistic and OLS models with era, discipline, and tier controls; figures here are drawn directly from the paper’s reported statistics.

Baton Index maintains leadership-succession intelligence on more than 10,000 academic leaders across twelve role families — business, medical, law, nursing, pharmacy, education, agriculture, public health, arts & sciences deans, provosts, and presidents — with sourced education histories, career pathways, and live appointment tracking. This brief is one view into that data.

PUT THE DATA TO WORK

Want the underlying benchmarks for a specific school, discipline, or region — or a co-branded version of this brief for a client? Reach the Baton Index team through the Insights panel in the app.

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